preceding years has left everyone protective and paranoid, and with it there is a feeling of players hoping to do enough to keep their place, above and beyond thinking what it might take to win a game of Test cricket.

Duncan Fletcher – from where I am now – is quite intimidating. He is steely-faced, looking like he is often deep inside his own thoughts. We do not communicate much. I just listen, always listen. Over the years, he will help me with my batting, and I will develop a respect for him and the way he has wrestled English cricket back from the brink. Him and Nasser are resuscitating the game, and when you are doing that, you don't always have time to look around and make sure if everyone's comfortable. That works for me. I have no urge to do anything but blend in, observe, learn and, more than anything else, bowl.

I've been on the pitch twice before I get to run in my most natural habitat; on the pitch with Anthony McGrath to receive our caps, and then to bat. I am using someone else's bat. It has no stickers or sponsors on it. Quite early on against Heath Streak, I feel the ball hit my pad and then cannon straight onto the middle of my bat for four. It's definitely out and definitely hit my pad first, but no one appeals. As always, I stay still, saying nothing, I just blink and gulp and hope for good luck.

As Zimbabwe begin their first innings, I have never stood at my mark and been so nervous. Matthew Hoggard has bowled the first over from the Pavilion End and I've just waited in the field as he does, watching his oddly familiar hustle, feeling strangely too close to it, knowing I will be next. I receive the ball, mark my run-up and for a momentary second reconsider if I even know how long my run-up is. Only two or three years ago I had been second best to Gaz Halley and Dave Brown while playing in Burnley's third team, kicking that jumper around. It was only a year ago that I fell over in front of the stumps for Lancashire seconds. It's only a handful of years since the journeys to that bench. Some coming-of-age films flicker through my mind: Macaulay Culkin asking whether he made his family disappear or Tom Hanks again in *Big*. I feel my tongue clamped down at the side of my mouth between my teeth, the giveaway I'm uncomfortable, that something is alien to me.

Nasser Hussain, our relationship until now a series of clipped sentences where he either praises or apologises to me, or screams obscenities in my general direction and I say nothing, comes up to me. 'Don't worry about the